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Ignacio Berroa

Drummer Ignacio Berroa was born on July 8, 1953 in Havana. He left Cuba in 1980 during the Mariel boatlift and within a year was playing with Dizzy Gillespie. His musical associations include work with Wynton Marsalis, Freddie Hubbard, Tito Puente, and the Lincoln Center Jazz Orchestra.

Ignacio was interviewed via Zoom on September 24, 2021 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: I'm very pleased to have Ignacio Berroa with me this morning, from Miami. And I'm in New York in Hamilton College and my name is Monk Rowe. Thanks a lot for joining me.

IB: My pleasure, thank you for having me, Monk.

MR: You know we, before our quote film was rolling, I think we have something in common in that Glenn Miller caught our ear in our youth. Is that correct?

IB: That is correct. Totally correct.

MR: Right. So musicians talk about, especially in the older vernacular about paying dues. And it's clear to me you've paid some dues simply to get here in the States, but before that I'm wondering was there any question about what your livelihood was going to be even before you came to the United States? At what point did you decide I'm going to be a musician?

IB: That was early. That was early, during my childhood. I decided that I wanted to be a musician when I was eleven years old. When I was eleven years old my father came to our apartment with two albums, one by the Nat King Cole Trio and the second one was the Glenn Miller Orchestra with Gene Krupa on drums. By that time I was studying the violin, because my father used to play the violin and my mother wanted me to be like my dad. So I started fooling around with the violin and went to the National School of the Arts in Cuba to study violin. But I was never interested. I was never interested on the violin, and was afraid to tell my father because I didn't want to hurt his feelings. My mom passed away when I was ten years old and I didn't want to betray my mother and her memory. But anyway once I heard Nat King Cole one day something struck me, and something in my body told me I love that music. That's the music I like.

MR: Did you study Mozart and the European composers on the violin?

IB: Oh well I didn't get that far thanks God. But my favorite violin concerto is Tchaikovsky. Tchaikovsky, Mendelssohn, those are my two favorite. But I didn't get that far. But one thing though, the musical training information in Cuba for many years, even after I left in

1980, was strictly classical. Everything was about Mozart, Tchaikovsky, Beethoven, Bach. Nothing about Afro-Cuban music or Cuban music in general.

MR: So the analogy that occurs to me in the United States about the time you were a teenager would have been rock music, that would have been the popular music for the most part that jazz had been really popular but sort of displanted by rock music. So what was the popular music in Cuba, like when you were let's say seventeen?

IB: Rock music. Why? Even though it was prohibited we went through a lot of different periods where we were even persecuted for playing American music, including rock or jazz. But I always say that Cuba, the Cuban musicians and everybody who loved American music, we have been lucky that the Island of Cuba is just 90 miles away from Key West. So that allowed us to stay informed in many ways, but now we're talking about music, of what was going on here in the United States. So we were attuned with everything that was going on here in the United States, when the weather permitted. It was not as easy as a lot of people think because in order to listen to the radio stations in the United States you need to have a good short wave radio. You need the second thing was having a good antenna. We had to do a lot of things in order to keep a good antenna on our roof. And the third thing was praying that the weather would be perfect.

MR: You know there's something about that that lasts and makes an impression I believe on a young person, that you have to go to those lengths to access something like that, and it makes it really special.

IB: Um hum. Say that again? I was talking on my phone.

MR: Okay. When you have to go to those lengths to, you know, get an antenna working and pray for the weather and have a good radio set, it makes that music all the much more special because it's not easily obtained.

IB: Well it was in my case in particular. I cannot talk about all the other musicians. But in my case in particular, Monk, the struggles that I went through in order to listen to that music, to study that music, so forth and so on, made it very very special. Because it was a long struggle about getting your antenna so forth and so on, and also being careful that your neighbor would not hear it, especially that you were listening to. Because you were listening to a radio station from the United States and at that time unfortunately the political situation in Cuba was that Americans were our enemies. Nowadays, after 52 years still in Cuba they are talking that Americans are going to invade at some point. So I grew up, I went through the missile crisis, I went through Bay of Pigs, I went through all of that, the many attempts by the CIA to overthrow Castro's government. So it was special. Because listening to a radio station was like promoting the music of the enemy.

MR: Was jazz in particular sort of banned by the Castro regime?

IB: Sometimes. Most of the time anything coming from the Western countries, like the Beatles, Miles Davis, John Coltrane, Dizzy Gillespie. That was the music of the enemy and the ideology back then was that the enemy was trying to penetrate our ideology any way possible. So music was one of the ways to penetrate our socialist ideology. So yes it was prohibited many times, it was prohibited to play music, you got in trouble for listening to the music. The only times we were able to play, once in a blue moon was when the government wanted to show, for some reason, that they were open about the music of the United States, just when it was for their convenience. Otherwise we went through a lot of hurdles, we got in trouble and even people went to jail for listening and dancing to Beatles music or Rolling Stones, so forth and so on.

MR: Can you remember specifically what it was about the Nat King Cole LP that grabbed your attention?

IB: Monk, I don't know — his voice, the music. What I can tell you is it was a trio: piano, bass and guitar. And I remember there was an album where he sang "When I Fall in Love," "Mona Lisa," "Our Love is Here to Stay." I realized after I moved to the United States because before 1980 my English was zero. I didn't know the meaning of "yes" so I learned to speak English here in the United States mainly during my period with the Dizzy Gillespie quartet, quintet, big band, etcetera, my ten year association with Dizzy Gillespie. So then here I learned the titles of the tunes and the lyrics. But it was just something that I can not explain. Unexplainable. I heard that, Monk, and that was something, I was possessed by that music. That's the way I can express it to you, to anyone. When I heard Nat King Cole, I mean I didn't say a word to my dad, I just heard that and I was like in shock. And I said to myself, what beautiful music. That's what I want to play. And no drums. No drum solo. But then I think the second day or the same day, once the Nat King Cole album was played he put on Glenn Miller. And when I heard that I said [scats "In the Mood"] when I heard that I said confirm! Confirm! That's the music that I want to play and I just realized that I don't want to study violin. I want to be a drummer. Another big hill. Because in Cuba you weren't able to go to a conservatory and study drums.

MR: So did you start paying more attention to the percussion end of things with Cuban music?

IB: Yes sir. My father was a violinist and he used to play for the Cuban National Radio Orchestra. So I used to go to the recordings were every day, Monday through Friday afternoons, and my father used to take me with him once I finished my day of schooling cause it was at that time just mornings. My father used to take me because my mom had passed away so he had no choice, taking me to his recordings. And that was the period when I was supposed to, on an every day basis [gap] music. The National Radio-TV Orchestra at that time there was a station called CMQ. The orchestra, they used to play

different styles of music because they used the recorded music for the radio and TV shows. And back in the days and to that period, the situation with American music and international music was not that heavy, ideologically speaking. I don't know if that word is correct. So I used to listen to Cuban music, I used to listen — they used to record Brazilian music, Argentinean music, music from different countries. I was exposed to Cuban music since I was little, because my father used to play the violin at charangas — orchestra formations in Cuba that play Cuban genres like danzon, cha-cha-cha, so my father played with quite a few famous charangas and when I was little at my house my mother always had the radio on. Always. I'm coming from a very poor family where a guy, a musician, had to support a family by doing gigs and you know, and gigs used to get canceled and so forth and so on. So quite a few times I saw in my houses guys coming and taking the TV out of the house because my father couldn't make the payments.

MR: Oh gee.

IB: But thanks God, we always had a radio. So my mom, she was a music fan, fanatic, and she had the radio on like in the beginning, ten, eleven AM in the morning, the radio was on and I was exposed to every type of music. Even to classical music.

MR: Was your mother a dancer? Did she like to dance?

IB: That's how she met my dad, going to a place, a society popular event and just started following the orchestra where my dad used to play, and that's how they met.

MR: I'm glad they met.

IB: Yeah. Me too, believe me.

MR: So you became a drumset player. And you mentioned earlier, when we first started chatting before we were filming that you're not a percussionist like a hand percussionist, so were you a little out of the ordinary as a drumset player before you came to the States, in Cuba? Don't some of the — Latin bands don't always have a drumset player, they sometimes just have a percussion section? Is that correct?

IB: Yeah. Cuban music has gone through different periods. I think the drumset appeared in Cuban music around 1924, 1926, around there. And the drumset appeared in Cuban music because bands, aside of playing Cuban music, they also had to please American and Spaniard tourists. So in order to play fox trots, a famous, a genre from Spain called Paso Dobles that in order to play that date needed a drumset. So that's when the drums appeared in Cuban music. That was the beginning. But then later on I think I might be wrong, a great Cuban singer, Benny More was the first one who added a drumset or recorded with a drumset. Little by little I cannot talk chronically about the history of the drumset in Cuban music but by the 70s I would say that 80 percent of the bands in Cuba started incorporating drumsets to the band. What happened is that drummers, most of the

drummers in Cuba used to play timbales. So they brought to the drumset the timbales way of playing. So for Cuban drummers from that era we didn't use timbales, we just used to take the snare off and the snares kind of sounded like timbales and they approach to the music was like if you were playing timbales with three drums and a bass drum. So that's how the drums started getting in and being part of Cuban music.

MR: Can you tell me about your first paying gig?

IB: My first paying gig was I started playing, after I finished from the National School of the Arts, I studied there for three years, and then I went to the National Conservatory of Havana. And there I met a guy that had a band, like a pop band. But we weren't prosecuted as other bands because our band had something in particular and it was that we used to play rock music from the Spanish groups that the Cuban government allowed to be playing on their national radio. The difference is that the lyrics of the tunes that we used to play, were in Spanish. Spanish lyrics. So but still, the rhythm was rock & roll. But also I don't remember that any of the lyrics were something like all you need is love — the Cuban government didn't like that. All you need is love. Obviously that was against the ideology because they used to say all you need is Communism. Communism is the future, and so forth and so on. We used to play lyrics and we had Spanish lyrics and we used to play private parties. So the first time I played a private party with that band I got paid. I don't know if you

[cuts out]

I think [15 or 50 @ 20:38] was the most that we used to get paid for playing private parties. So that was my first paying gig.

MR: All right. I'll never forget my first paying gig. I made $4 on my first paying gig.

IB: Wow. Well yeah, I beat you, because once I arrived [cuts out] I did a three dollars gig. Three dollars gig. I'm going to go to my grave regretting that I didn't save those three dollars and frame them.

MR: Yes.

IB: But I made a three dollar gig in Europe once that represented me at the end, quite a few dollars.

MR: All right. So leading up to the Mariel boatlift, was there a period of a number of years where you started to think I really am unhappy here, I want to pursue this music career but it's not going to happen here. I mean what was your motivation to come to the States in such a manner that you did?

IB: I always, Monk, since I started using my mind, I'm also I have to say that my dad, who was a huge Fidel Castro fan up to the point that my father fought on Bay of Pigs defending the Cuban regime. In 1965 he broke ties with the revolution because he started seeing that Castro's promises — that everything was like a lie. He thought that Castro

was a liar, that he was not doing what he promised from the beginning, so he broke ties with the revolution and

[gap @ 22:55]

with the Cuban government. And that in a sense helped me out to determine the different direction. But another musical event, before my father broke ties with the government, that was a musical thing that made me decide that living in Cuba under that regime was not for me. And that was when I started seeing that young people, the youth in Cuba that used to like the Beatles and the Rolling Stones, started to be prosecuted and that we were at parties listening and dancing to the Beatles with no drugs, no amount of alcohol. We were just 14, 15, 16, 17, young guys. And we were dancing through the, with the music [sings] All you need is love. And the police will appear and stop the party and then one of the guys might start an argument with the policeman and then that guy was taken to jail, then later they started taking a bunch of people to jail and started cutting their hairs and cutting their tight pants. And I remember I told my father if this revolution is afraid of four guys with long hair, three guitars and a drums this thing is not solid. So that was the beginning. So to make a long story short since I was I would say twelve or thirteen years old I wanted to leave that place. I knew that Cuba was not for me. And the other thing, Cuba was not for me because one of the things I have never been able to incorporate into my personality into my life is something very near it, in life, for some people, which is hypocrisy. I cannot behave [gap] demonstrate to you, "Oh yeah, loyalty for Fidel, oh yeah, Communism." And then when I get a chance defect. I always was straightforward. I always expressed what I liked, and that got me into a lot of trouble. It have got me along the way because I grew up — right now I'm 68 years old and I have found through life that on numerous occasions telling the truth got you consequences. But in the case of Cuba, yes, since I was like thirteen years old I wanted to leave, but I didn't have the opportunity of doing so.

MR: Did you manage to evade any arrests or, you know trouble with the authorities yourself?

IB: I was able, I was never, because I knew I must never argue. If I was at a party and the police arrived the first thing I would do is to tell my friends, "Let's go." Because I learned from the early days that you don't argue with police. You don't argue with them. And I saw a lot of my friends being taken to the station because they were rebels and like I said they used to cut their hairs, cut the tight pants, and the argument could escalate at the police station and that could have — and ended up many times in people serving one or two years in jail.

MR: So when this opportunity came, if I understand the boatlift, there is a short window where Castro allowed quite a number of people to leave. How did you qualify for that?

IB: I didn't qualify. I escaped. Meaning, there was so much confusion. That was an event that surprised Castro, it really did. And the events, the Mariel events were happening because for at the Peruvian Embassy in Havana. A group of people took a bus and they slammed the bus into the Peruvian Embassy. All the embassies in Cuba that granted, let's say, an embassy from capitalist countries, all of them had guards. Guards. People waiting in line. You wouldn't have allowed to not even walk at embassy. I remember I was dating a lady that at the end became my wife in Cuba and she used to live two blocks away from the Argentinean consulate or embassy. And I used to pick her up and we were started going down the street and you know we were young and so we were like talking and kissing and holding hands, not realizing that we were about to walk through this street where the embassy was at. And we were coming and talking and the next thing we will hear was a whistle and saw the guard signaling us to go to the sidewalk. You weren't even allowed to walk through the middle of the street. In the middle of the street that was a no walking zone. So every embassy had guards. So this guy's bus at the Peruvian Embassy they had an exchange of crossfire because the Cuban government claimed that those guys had gone. That was never proven. There was a crossfire and one of the guards was killed, got killed. Castro asked the Peruvian Embassy to surrender, to give those people back to him and the Peruvian ambassador told him this guy has asked for political asylum and my country grants belief in political asylum, and then I'm going to give the guy back to you. Those guys are going to Peru. And then he said, "Well I'm not going to allow them to go to Peru." He got into a feud with the ambassador and then he got mad. He was a very [gap] guy and he said, "Well if you don't give me the guys I'm going to take the guards off your embassy." And the ambassador said, "We need no guards. It is you that have guards in our embassy to prevent people coming here to ask for political asylum. He took the guards off and in less than 24 hours, Monk, 10,000 people walked into the house. The embassy was like a huge house, like one of those houses in Connecticut or Upstate New York you know, upper class people. That was the embassy. Now can you imagine 10,000 people in your front yard or around your houses jumping the fences and then in 24 hours you have 10,000 people. So they had to close the streets and so forth and so on. He got mad, and that's when he said, "It seems like there are a group of people in this country that don't want to be here. They don't like the revolution, so I'm going to rehabilitate this port for everyone. He said that very clear. Everyone who wanted to leave the island, do so. So immediately families here in Miami started taking and renting boats and going to Cuba to get their families. That's how, in that confusion, I was in serious political trouble in Cuba for being a big mouth, and I called my family in New York. I have family in New York and one of my family went down to Cuba to pick me up. So among that confusion, because then Castro realized that professionals were leaving the island,

doctors, engineers and so on and so forth. So in order for him to take the attention away from that he started sending prisoners, people that were suffering from dementia, he started to make it look like every Cuban that wanted to leave the island was a low class person.

MR: I see.

IB: But anyway in that confusion I escaped. I left. They didn't realize who I was and I was lucky. I was super lucky. And I left the island.

MR: And you were about 17? Is that right?

IB: No I was 26.

MR: Oh you were 26.

IB: I was 26 when I left Cuba. I was 26. I arrived here in May 1980 and I turned 27 July 1980. I was 26 years old.

MR: This is a bit off, more like current events but I wonder, when you look at what's happening on our Southern border right now with all the Haitian people who are very desperate to get into the country, what do you think about that?

IB: Man it makes me sad to see that whole

[gap @ 34:16]

I don't know if it is correct, it is like a Catch-22. I don't know. It is very hard. Because those people wanted to come to this country to look for opportunities, and now they are denied to get into the country because the country has a situation that a half million illegal immigrants and they don't know what to do. So at the end you know those who are suffering are the people. I'm pro-immigrant. I'm an immigrant. And I know thousands of those people have the intention of coming to this country to contribute, looking for progress, looking for a better life to contribute something to this country that we call the United Nations of America. So I'm proud of that but on the other hand I'm not a politician. I don't know what they are thinking. I don't know how they are managing the budget, so forth and so on. They are politicians. But me as a human I feel very sorry and I'm impatient and I'm on their side because I'm an immigrant. I'm a Cuban immigrant that got the opportunity to get here to make it by saying this as a joke, thanks to the mistakes that Jimmy Carter and Fidel Castro made. Castro said, "You can leave." And Jimmy Carter said, "Open arms and here I am."

MR: And here you are, and you arrived in the United States and within a year you're playing with Dizzy Gillespie. Not bad.

IB: Not bad at all. But it has been, you know I have gone through — I'll tell you something, Monk, the passing of my mother was a big blow in my life because she died suddenly from childbirth. She had a heart attack and bye. I saw my mom today and the next day I saw her in a casket at a funeral home. And I thought that after that my life would be

terrible. And I had some of that, right. But on the other hand I have been blessed. I have been blessed because the way I was able to, I have been able to— the musical career that I have had the way all the events happened when it was unfolding, it is like a movie. So sometimes I don't take it for granted, I have been in this country for 41 years and there is not a day that goes by that I don't say to myself, "Ignacio, wow." You know and sometimes I think I don't want to wake up and realize that this has been a dream. So

MR: Well it's a darn good dream.

IB: Yeah. I have been blessed. I have been blessed also I can say, because I'm, you know, I can say that [gap] result of my dedication [gap]

38:11

I don't know what is the other word, a lot of dedication. You can have the talent, the dedication, effort, but today you need to make these other parts that have to fit into the equation and make everything happen, and it is a little bit of luck. You have to be in the right place at the right time and that happened to me. That happened to me.

MR: It seems like you were the perfect choice for Dizzy Gillespie. I mean here he is a bebop innovator with an intense love of Cuban music and here you are, someone who can do both.

IB: Well yes. I think that, I'm sure that was the key. This was a guy that was always looking for new things. He was the guy that, by the suggestion of the great Cuban musician Mario Bauza, he hired [gap]

39:25

so he saw something in me obviously, that showed us [gap] he saw a guy that had the potential of becoming a bebop jazz drummer

bring to that style, to that genre all the Afro-Cuban elements that he loved. So I think I was the perfect [gap] for what he had in mind rhythmically speaking about fusioning Afro-Cuban rhythms with jazz. And the reason why that happened was because Mario Bauza was the one who saw me playing and recommended it to him. Dizzy didn't see me playing nowhere. Mario Bauza saw me playing and called him up and told him about me.

MR: Did you have an audition with Dizzy?

IB: No. No, no, no, no, no, no. He was, one day he had an engagement in New York. He was desperate looking for his drummer because his favorite drummer wasn't able to leave Boston because they shut down the city due to a snowstorm and Dizzy had an engagement at a club in New York at Fat Tuesday. So Dizzy, once his drummer told him that he wasn't able to arrive to New York, he has been looking for drummers. He opened up his phone book and started calling people, calling people, calling people. Everybody was busy and then suddenly into his desperation he remembered, oh Mario Bauza told me about a Cuban drummer. So he called Mario, explained the situation, and asked Mario,

"Do you think that that guy you told me is available?" And Mario told him, "Okay, let me call him up, I don't know if he is available." Mario called me, I was available, and then Mario said to me, okay — it was very funny because the phone rang and Mario asked me, "Do you want to play with Dizzy Gillespie tonight?" Out of the clear blue that was the question and by that time Mario and I were friends, we were friends, and I told him, "Mario come on, you're too old for this type of joke at this time." And then he said, "No, I'm serious." He explained the situation to me and I told him I wanted to play with Dizzy Gillespie since I was born. So Mario called Dizzy, told Dizzy, "Hey we've got the drummer already, he is available, he's on his way to Fat Tuesday." So that's how I [gap]. My English was zero. I remember telling Mario, "Mario, you're going to be there, right?" Because I needed a translator. And Mario said to me, "No it's all there. You got it. Boom and he hung up on me. So I don't know — so it is your problem. So a friend of mine came and picked me up, put the drums in — so I went to the club. We arrived to the club and through my friend who was Jerry Gonzalez, the conga and trumpet player who was a great friend of mine.

[gap]

When I show him my four fingers it's straight ahead swing. Now when I show him six fingers that means Afro-Cuban 6/8. That way I do this with my fist — when I see my fist, I close my fist that means stop. And then when I point my index finger to him that means drum solo. Let's go. That was the audition. No audition. Those were the instructions. Right to the stage I didn't know the arrangements but this I tell the students, about listening to music, about getting prepared. I was familiar with "Night in Tunesia," with "Groovin' High," with "Manteca," with "Tin Tin Deo," "Salt Peanuts." I knew the tunes. I didn't know the arrangements, but I knew the tunes.

MR: You know you said —

IB: So I managed to — yup?

MR: You said, this is a great story, and it reminds me a bit of the video that you did, one of your early videos and you were addressing a question about listening to the Latin rhythms and trying to figure them out, and your response was, "You must listen to the whole band to make sense of what's going on."

IB: That's correct.

MR: So I would guess that that was a practice of yours, listening to the whole band, including Dizzy if it was a Dizzy record, which served you well.

IB: Yup. Yup. You have to listen to everything. That's one of the things that is going to link you to success, learning the genre. For many years I have seen a lot of people, and especially, but it also happens with jazz. A lot of the young musicians, they just concentrate on their instrument. They just concentrate about getting, playing the right

scales, the right intervals, the embouchure or whatever or the instrument technique and they don't care about the vocabulary. How? Why is this happening? What the drummer is doing. Why the bass player — you have to learn how to comp, on the drums because some people, some musicians who in my opinion can not play several types of music, they call that "the rules." There are no rules, it is vocabulary. It's something that you need to learn, and even you can expand the vocabulary, take the vocabulary to a different level, but there is a foundation that in my opinion if you know that foundation, if you study, if you learn that it's going to allow you to take that music to a different level. It is the vocabulary. And it's the vocabulary that you need to learn. And that vocabulary cannot be taught with this accent that I'm talking to you now, the accent, that my English has. That vocabulary, you have to find the right accent and you have to do your homework. You have to do it. Because when you're going to play that music it's the same thing that I have always been talking about, the so-called Latin music, you need to learn that. [gap] self respect that you know, that [gap] has evolved out of music or genres. I don't know how it's correct, genre or style of music. So forgive me. That's something that you have to dedicate your time and learn. It's not like okay you learn two patterns, two Afro-Cuban or what everybody call "two Latin patterns" and you are an expert and you can play that music. It's not like that. There is something to be learned. So that's my opinion. And that's something that I have been saying for years. It is a vocabulary, bebop, that is a vocabulary. Rock. It is a vocabulary. Cha-cha-cha, a rumba, samba, bossa nova, — those genres, there is a vocabulary that you need to learn if you really want to play that and to be effective.

MR: Yeah. I know what you're saying. Most of us thought, oh yeah, I can play a Latin tune, if someone wants a Latin tune we'd play "Girl from Ipanema" and we think you know, okay we filled that.

IB: Exactly. Exactly. Yeah and the thing is that, listen I'm a very, very straightforward person. I came to the United States, I wanted to be a jazz drummer. I wanted to see my heroes because this person that is talking to you now through Zoom, my ultimate dream, Monk, when I was in Cuba and when I thought that I would never be able to leave that place, my ultimate dream was seeing my heroes on a video. On a video. That was my ultimate dreams because I thought, even though I put out into the universe that I wanted to leave that place and obviously it happened. But at some point, many times I was discouraged and I thought that I would have never been able to leave that place, leave that island and get to New York. So being able to come here, I always say God gave me the scholarship to come to New York and learn that music that I always wanted to play. So I'm still taking advantage of that because I'm still listening to the music I love and learning and finding about the history of that music. I have to play straight ahead jazz and

I live in the United States. I didn't come to the United States to make a living playing Cuban music. I came here to play the music that I wanted to play. So for Americans you don't have to because hey I'm an American this is my country, what are the possibilities that I'm going to make a living playing with a Latin band.

MR: That's a great analogy. I was able to do an interview with Mike Longo and he told me this little anecdote about Dizzy from the film "A Night in Havana."

IB: Um hum.

MR: And I'm going to sort of read a quote from his interview here. A woman asked him, "Where does your music come from." And he said, "Do you really want to know?" And she said well yes. You know what he said? He said "my asshole."

IB: That's why they called him "Dizzy."

MR: So then Mike went on to say that this actually has a name, a Kundalini Energy, like an ultimate life force, that there's actually a philosophy about this energy that's stored in the bass of your spine and if you operate correctly it will go to your head and allow you to do certain things.

IB: Wow.

MR: So I wonder if you had a comment on that?

IB: No. I don't know because we never talked about that. I remember him saying when the student asked him what was the first thing, how he was able to play those high notes, he used to say the first thing that you have to do is you have to tighten your asshole. That was the first thing that he would say. So that answer that he gave to that lady in Cuba, we never talked about that theory. We never talked about it.

MR: You know talking about music between musicians I find fascinating because usually if I ask the question of some performing musicians do you all talk about what you're going to do or do you talk after you're done? And most of them say not really, that it happens on the bandstand. So I wonder if Dizzy Gillespie talked to you about what he wanted?

IB: Oh yes. Oh yes. Yes. Dizzy was famous for being a pain in the neck for drummers. Especially for drummers. And yes, he wanted to hear certain things in particular like for example Dizzy was not too keen or he didn't like playing the cymbal behind him like let's say in a modern way of playing it. He didn't like moving that straight ahead pulse, playing around. He wanted to hear [scats]. He was not too keen about [scats]. That type of thing, he would always say to me, "Ignacio, behind me you play [scats]. Behind Sam Rivers and behind Ed Cherry the guitar — , you play whatever you want. But behind me I want to hear — every drummer that went through that band had that famous 22 Chinese cymbal with rivets, that was the sound he liked to hear when he played. You had to play on that cymbal and he would ask you to play that. And also he taught me a great deal of the bebop vocabulary that a lot of the young musicians call "rules" because I want to be

me, I have to play like me and so forth and so on. Vocabulary. He taught me a great deal about the vocabulary, how to fill the holes. When he would play a phrase, a phrase, and then filling when he was gasping for air [scats]. That's where you play your fill. You know?

MR: Yeah. Don't play over his lick, play in the cracks.

IB: Exactly. Exactly. While he's playing you can be complementing, very soft you know, and underneath on the underground, but not competing with him. Then when the soloist gasps for air, that's the moment where you can play your fills. That's part of the vocabulary. That's part of the vocabulary, things that should be learned. And I learned that very well. That was the type of thing he taught me. We talked about rhythms, we talked about fusion rhythms, he was — at some point he was with me, I was like his rhythm machine. We would be on the stage and Dizzy would think about a rhythm, he will come to the drum, whisper the rhythm in my ear, and I would play it back to him. So we were always having that type of communication. But yeah, he was — the thing he was very demanding like all the band leaders, he also was demanding about the type of chord he wanted to hear while he was improvising. Dizzy Gillespie was like, I tell people, being with Dizzy Gillespie was like being at a university of jazz. But yes, he was demanding. Most of the band leaders that I remember back in the days they were very demanding. They knew what they wanted to hear and so forth and so on. And I think that was very good.

MR: Was Dizzy a spiritual man?

IB: Yes. Very. But Dizzy was, listen Monk, he was one of my best friends. We became [gap]. Dizzy wasn't perfect, he was a human being. But he was a rare breed. He was an incredible human being, very spiritual. He was amazing. He was amazing human being. I don't know where he came from. I don't know where he came from.

MR: It's telling that you say that because going back to Mike Longo, he said he was the most amazing human being I ever met and he was aware of the divinity in Dizzy. He felt that there was something divine about him.

IB: Yes sir. Yes sir. Dizzy was amazing. And I'm proud when I say he was a human being. I had arguments with him and we were so close that sometimes he would do something that I thought was incorrect and I would tell him and he would listen to me and he said, "Yeah, yeah you're right." So, but he was from a different place. Dizzy Gillespie was incredible. So there is not a day that goes by that that I don't think about him. And I'm proud to say — the other day I was doing an interview I was telling someone, and now speaking about me, I told the person, "How many drummers in the world can say that they were Dizzy Gillespie's drummer, but how many of them, how many musicians can say they were Dizzy Gillespie's friend?" We were friends. Close, very close, very close.

MR: That's terrific. And the first gig with Dizzy, just before you told that story you had said with all the other things, you need a little bit of luck and I think you had it.

IB: Oh yes, oh yes. Could you imagine all the names, the drummer's names Dizzy Gillespie had in his book? And he started calling people [gap] were busy. I could have been busy that night playing a little gig somewhere. And it happens that I was at my aunt's apartment in the Bronx doing nothing that day. So it was meant to be. It is luck. I always tell people Dizzy and I would have crossed paths anyway because before joining the Dizzy Gillespie band I had auditioned to be Mongo Santamaria's drummer. So I would run into Dizzy somewhere at a festival, here, in Europe, somewhere. And you know eventually [gap]. But the way it happened it was too soon, because I played that night, it was just a one night gig. I made a good impression on him obviously because like six months later when his drummer left he called up Mario and he told Mario, I'm looking for a drummer so if the Cuban guy is available tell him that he's got the gig.

MR: Who was it that you replaced? I'm trying to remember.

IB: I replaced a drummer, a young drummer at that time, Tommy Campbell. Great drummer. He was graduated from Berklee. He was Dizzy's drummer at that time then Tommy left to go and play with John McLaughlin and Dizzy called me. That's how I got the gig.

MR: Well Ignacio, we've been at this for like over an hour, and we have to do like maybe two or three more hours. But I wonder, on a global sense, what do you see as the role and the possibilities of music? You've traveled overseas and played for a lot of different populations. Do you have a thought you can share about what you've seen music is capable of?

IB: Music in general? Or jazz music?

MR: Jazz music specifically I guess.

IB: It is a shame to see how jazz music doesn't have the exposure it used to have years ago to globally. So the way I have seen it now, maybe I'm a pessimist but for me the prognosis is not too good. Young musicians are going in different directions of course, the young people are the ones who always move, taking music to a different direction, but I don't know if they're taking it to the right direction or not. Time will tell. But on the other hand there are a lot of musicians who are studying and paying attention to all music, let's put it that way. But I think that if we wanted to continue playing this music that we lovingly call jazz, [gap] nothing wrong with moving, taking this music a step further, go ahead. But we need, especially the young people, the young musicians — to me it is imperative to learn about the history, to learn about the past, what our heroes they did. We need to learn that. We need to learn the foundation in order to move the wheel to a different place. Dizzy Gillespie, this is not me, Dizzy Gillespie said this many years ago. We need to have a foot upfront and one in the back. One up front and one in the back. So I'm not

saying this, Dizzy Gillespie said this many years ago. And that's my opinion. We cannot try to move jazz to a different place if we don't know what our predecessors did, why we got to this point. The other thing is promoters, the businessmen, hey, everybody wants to make money. Unfortunately jazz is not a music that brings a lot of people to venues. It is hard to fill a stadium with jazz bands, but I think everybody should have the responsibility of educating people. There are a lot of people in the world that love jazz and want to hear jazz, but to bring back festivals, that type of thing that has been disappearing because the business aspect, because it is not profitable so I don't want to invest money in announcing my product at a jazz festival and so forth and so on. So that's something that should be done in order to preserve this. Otherwise, if that doesn't happen, like right now with the pandemic so forth and so on, I hope that at some point the government gives jazz musicians and musicians in general some type of funding because otherwise I don't see it. Now I'm talking even about classical music, not just jazz. Music in general.

MR: Thank you for that answer.

IB: If we don't get help we're going to be in trouble. Now you can say in English what I have been trying —

MR: I think you're doing fine and I'm envious that you're bilingual. Do you always have music in your head?

IB: Most of the time, yes.

MR: Is there a thing you do if you feel like you need to not have it in your head for a while? Is there anything that you do?

IB: Oh yes, oh yes. My real passion is baseball. I'm a frustrated baseball player. I'm a frustrated baseball player, and I know a lot about baseball. So when I want to get out of the world I don't watch baseball too much anymore because the things that have been happening in baseball for the past few years, the Houston Astros kind of really bothered me a lot. But anyway, I have a playstation full, and I play baseball with my playstation and I go out of the world. Because you know you can play 162 games, the game — keep the stats, and so it's very good. So that's my passion. That's a secret I want to share. I change, I change everything I have done in music [gap] possibility of [gap]